

Aditya Natraj

Aditya Natraj is the CEO of Piramal Foundation, the philanthropic arm of the Piramal Group. A chartered accountant turned social entrepreneur, he has spent nearly two decades building systems that transform public institutions — from schools and primary health centres to district administrations — so that India's most marginalised communities receive the services they deserve.

Education

- Bachelor of Commerce (B.Com), Mumbai.
- MBA from INSEAD

Career

Aditya began his professional life at KPMG in Chennai, where he worked as a consultant for five years. Yearning for greater purpose, he joined the start-up team of a technology company in Europe, before returning to India with a question that would define his career: why were 80 million children dropping out of India's schools?

Volunteering with grassroots organisations, he saw the answer lay not in children, but in systems. Schools were poorly led, principals had no training in management or motivation, and governments had no model for investing in the people who ran schools. He joined Pratham's Gujarat operations for five years, immersing himself in what large-scale education reform actually demands on the ground.

In 2008, he founded Kaivalya Education Foundation (KEF) with a singular focus: train government school principals to lead. The Piramal Group funded the first pilot in Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan, where 100 rural school principals enrolled in workshops on managing schools, motivating teachers, and engaging communities. Over time, KEF expanded into multiple states, trained thousands of principals, and eventually merged into Piramal Foundation, where Aditya took on the role of CEO.

His career has since spanned the full arc of public systems transformation — education, healthcare, livelihoods, tribal development, and governance — always through the same conviction: real scale comes only when governments own the change.

Awards and Recognition

- Ashoka Fellow — recognised as a leading social entrepreneur driving systemic change in India
- Echoing Green Fellow — selected for outstanding early-stage social impact leadership
- Times Now Amazing Indian Award — Education category, for transformative contribution to India's public education system



Leadership at Piramal Foundation

Under Aditya's leadership, Piramal Foundation has evolved into one of India's most consequential public systems transformation organisations. It has impacted over 113 million lives across 27 states and 2 union territories, operating at the intersection of philanthropy, government partnership, and grassroots community engagement.

His approach rests on three principles. First, do not bypass the state — co-create with it. Piramal Foundation embeds its work inside government systems rather than running parallel structures. In Bihar, a \$2 million philanthropic investment in Health Command and Control Centres enabled real-time monitoring across 12,800 facilities, catalysing \$37.5 million in state government funding. Second, invest in people, not just programmes. The Gandhi Fellowship, the Piramal School of Leadership, and the Karuna Fellowship are all vehicles for building the leadership capacity of those who serve at the front lines of government. Third, think in decades, not projects. Piramal Foundation has stayed invested in Rajasthan's education reform for over fifteen years, seeing it through changes in government and policy.

Aditya's philosophy of 'compassionate capitalism' — balancing profit with purpose, and asking corporate India to treat CSR as systemic investment rather than transactional giving — has influenced how Piramal Foundation positions itself in the wider development ecosystem. He serves on the governing boards of the Quality Council of India, Akanksha Foundation, and Bridgespan India.

His vision for 2047 is ambitious and concrete: uplift 400 million of India's most marginalised citizens by strengthening the institutions that serve them — not by replacing the state, but by making it work.